

Chapter 81-5

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Last night at the Liang family was indeed a "bloodbath."

Qiu Zimin and Father Liang had brought back their long-lost daughter—Guo Xinran.

Before this daughter arrived, everyone had already obtained her information and knew she had lived in poverty. And Liang Xinzhou had finally, under Liang Xinhe's persuasion, decided to wait and see how things developed, and hadn't moved out.

That evening when Guo Xinran came back, they even held a welcome ceremony for her.

Her appearance was similar to Liang Wanwan's. Even though they had never spent time together growing up, there was still that bit of blood connection.

Qiu Zimin also showed a rare smile in recent days. On the surface, the family appeared harmonious, which was passable enough.

Except that Liang Xinzhou's expression wasn't very friendly—but he was always like that, often wearing a stern face. Even Ling Dang would usually complain, "Why does Big Uncle always like to keep a straight face and frown?"

She would even occasionally imitate Liang Xinzhou's serious expression.

Everyone was used to it.

But the newly arrived younger sister, after dinner, quietly asked Qiu Zimin in a timid, trembling voice, "Does Big Brother not like me? Did I do something to make Big Brother angry?"

She had asked Qiu Zimin quietly, but Ling Dang happened to overhear.

Ling Dang said from the side: "No, New Auntie, my Big Uncle has always been like that."

Guo Xinran blinked, looking like she was about to cry. "But he's so gentle with Ling Dang. Only with me... I feel like I did something wrong and made Big Brother unhappy."

Upon hearing this, Qiu Zimin's face immediately darkened. She went to confront Liang Xinzhou and lectured him: "Can't you just smile? Your sister being able to come back is a huge blessing. Why are you still wearing that expression like you bear some deep grudge?"

Yu Wan, who was sitting nearby chatting with Sun Meirou, heard this and couldn't help but defend Liang Xinzhou. "Mom, Xinzhou has always been like this. It's not like he looks like he bears some deep grudge."

"How is it not?" Qiu Zimin glanced at her. "Why are you defending him? I'm talking to him, not to you."

These words were rather infuriating, which prompted Liang Xinzhou to immediately respond: "My wife can't defend me?"

He was simply speaking up for Yu Wan, but unexpectedly, Qiu Zimin got angry the moment she heard it. "Right, right, right, you two husband and wife are so good together. Your wife just defends you, and everything I do is wrong, is that it?"

"I didn't say that." Liang Xinzhou said, "There's no need to over-interpret."

"I'm over-interpreting? Liang Xinzhou, what are you saying? Are you also trying to say I'm wrongly accusing you? Anyone can see that your cold face today is deliberately shown to us." At this point, Qiu Zimin started settling old and new scores together. "Do you think I don't know what you're thinking? You think if you drive Xinran away, Liang Shi will come back? Let me tell you—impossible!"

Liang Xinzhou's brow furrowed tightly. "I didn't say that."

Yu Wan, sitting to the side, couldn't stay seated anymore and said coldly: "Mom, how can you say that? Xinzhou has never targeted anyone."

"Shut up! I'm talking to Liang Xinzhou." Qiu Zimin said harshly, "You don't have a say in this."

Yu Wan was furious. "But you can't wrongly accuse him like this either! He works so hard every day. You all don't go to the company, and even Dad can leave Haizhou for three days. If you want to bring your daughter back, then bring her back. Everyone has welcomed her. Why must everyone smile? Liang Xinzhou didn't even smile much when we took our wedding photos!"

Yu Wan was different from Sun Meirou.

Sun Meirou had a gentle personality. When speaking with Qiu Zimin normally, she was always deferential and respectful, afraid of displeasing her.

But Yu Wan's family was also quite powerful, and she was the only daughter. She had always been busy working at her own family's company, so her personality was much more assertive. Usually, because she didn't spend much time at home, she wouldn't clash with Qiu Zimin.

But now, in front of the whole family, with Qiu Zimin speaking to Liang Xinzhou like this, Yu Wan couldn't stand it.

The two started arguing, and Sun Meirou even tugged at Yu Wan's hem, signaling her to say less.

Qiu Zimin was also stunned by what Yu Wan said, but as the mother-in-law, in front of so many people, she naturally couldn't lose face.

So Qiu Zimin said harshly: "Shut up! I'm talking to Liang Xinzhou. You don't have a say in this."

"Mom." Liang Xinzhou stood up and blocked Yu Wan behind him. "What do you mean by that?"

"What do you mean?" Qiu Zimin glared at him. "Do you have to break with the family just for a Liang Shi? We're the ones who share blood ties with you."

"No." Liang Xinzhou looked at her and said calmly, "This has nothing to do with Liang Shi right now. She's not even in this house. I'm only asking you—what did you mean just now?"

Qiu Zimin was taken aback. "Are you questioning me?"

"Simply asking." Liang Xinzhou adopted his business negotiation stance. "Why doesn't Yu Wan have a say? Is it wrong for her to speak up for me? Why are you being fierce with her?"

"She was being nosy." Qiu Zimin said coldly, "And you—why do you keep wearing that cold face? Everyone's happy, only you..."

"Yu Wan just said it." Liang Xinzhou scoffed lightly. "I didn't even smile when I took wedding photos with her. I've lived for over thirty years, and I barely smiled at my own wedding. Why should I smile just because she's back? Am I someone who sells smiles?"¹

The conversation was veering further off track, with cold, biting questions.

Liang Xinhe had Sun Meirou take Ling Dang back to her room, away from this smokeless battlefield. But as Ling Dang went upstairs, she pouted: "New Auntie thought Big Uncle's cold face meant he disliked her, but I already explained it."

Ling Dang even gave a cold snort. "Big Uncle has always been like that. I never said he disliked me. Hmph."

Sun Meirou immediately covered Ling Dang's mouth and carried her upstairs.

Ling Dang's words made everyone shift their attention to Guo Xinran. But Guo Xinran looked at Qiu Zimin with teary eyes: "Mom, that's not what I meant."

Seeing her like this, Qiu Zimin's heart immediately ached terribly. She quickly said: "Mom knows. Don't cry."

Then Qiu Zimin told Liang Xinzhou and his wife to apologize to Guo Xinran.

The more Liang Xinzhou listened, the more outrageous he found it. He said coldly: "Do you really think I'm someone who sells smiles?"

Qiu Zimin was furious, but she redirected the conflict toward Yu Wan. "It's your wife who corrupted you. What's this about selling smiles? We're all family, getting along harmoniously—why use such an embarrassing term?"

"What does this have to do with Yu Wan?" Liang Xinzhou firmly protected Yu Wan. "Why don't you say that you've gone too far? She comes back, I throw her a welcome banquet—do I also have to coddle her? Is that really necessary?"

At that moment, Qiu Zimin's phone rang. She answered it, and her finger accidentally touched the speakerphone button, so the voice on the phone reached everyone's ears.

The housekeeper said: "Madam, the villa at Shallow Water Bay has been sold for thirteen million yuan. Please check if the money has arrived in the account. The Third Young Miss has already been informed. She'll be there on Sunday..."

Qiu Zimin suddenly panicked and hurriedly hung up.

But everyone had already heard what they needed to hear.

Shallow Water Bay?

Wasn't that where Liang Shi lived?

Liang Xinzhou was shocked. He questioned coldly: "You sold the wedding house that was given to Liang Shi?"

Qiu Zimin had been feeling a bit guilty, but hearing him ask like this, she immediately said unhappily: "Can't I sell my own things? It's just one house. If she's capable, she can go buy one herself."

"You..." Liang Xinzhou was so angry he was at a loss for words. "You... what are you saying?"

Qiu Zimin became more confident. "I'm telling her to buy her own place. Didn't she feel that staying in the Liang family wronged her? Didn't she think I haven't treated her well all these years? Then I might as well live up to my bad reputation! I put so much effort into treating her well, indulging her, and all I got in return was being blamed. Then let her go on her own. After all, she doesn't want to be in the Liang family anymore anyway."

"You raised her to be that way, and now you want her to go fend for herself?" Liang Xinzhou laughed in anger. "What are you thinking? Mom, have you lost your mind..."²

"Slap—"

Before he could finish, Qiu Zimin slapped him across the face. Her eyes were already red with fury. "Liang Xinzhou, what did you just say about me?!"

Liang Xinzhou's glasses were knocked off, landing at Yu Wan's feet.

Yu Wan was stunned. She opened her mouth but didn't know what to say, and could only hold Liang Xinzhou's hand tightly.

A moment later, Yu Wan was so angry her voice was trembling. She accused angrily: "Look at yourself right now—you're the one who's lost your mind!"

Qiu Zimin was so angry she raised her hand to hit Yu Wan, but Liang Xinzhou caught her arm.

Liang Xinzhou glared at her fiercely and said coldly: "Enough!"

1. "Someone who sells smiles" (賣笑的) — This phrase literally refers to someone who smiles for money, traditionally used to describe entertainers or courtesans. Liang Xinzhou uses it sarcastically to ask if he's expected to smile on command like a performer. ⇐
2. "Lost your mind" (鬼迷心竅) — A Chinese idiom literally meaning "possessed by ghosts" or "bewitched," used to describe someone who has become confused or made irrational decisions, as if their mind has been clouded by supernatural forces. ⇐